of the Marathi-speaking diaspora just like the attendance and craze for Durga Puja festival celebrations has risen with the growth of the Bengali diaspora. In such a milieu, the English language and Chinese food have emerged as two major attractions that bind ties as they keep everyone at a common disadvantage. Not only is English the language of the elite, it is the language of aspiration in the 21st century. And the distinctly Indian-Chinese food, remote from what the Chinese actually offer, has infiltrated menus across restaurants in India. Asked what they miss most when they go abroad, Indians are quite likely to say ‘Chinese food’, even in China.

Sub-national diasporas are also stereotyped in the same way as national diasporas are, as they tend to cluster in certain segments due to networks, strong peer pressures and demonstration effects. Odiya cooks and plumbers, Malayali nurses and secretaries and Bengali economists have all gained a reputation for excelling in what they do, across the country, if not the world. As an offshoot, economists in India often mull over learning a third language, Bengali, in addition to English and maths, to keep up with frenetic academic conversations.

A Matter of Water and Steam

Over the past century, the Indian international diaspora changed from a plantation (and not necessarily indenture) dominated diaspora in a few countries to a diverse diaspora spanning the world. In the erstwhile plantation world, caste dissolved into race or ethnicity as a marker of identity. The international diaspora that was once fairly representative of the Indian population is now a much more elite diaspora with miniscule representation of the lowest castes in recent waves of outmigration. There is religious diversity in the diaspora overall but with wide variations in selected migration corridors. Women’s representation is low in the zones of the Great Indian Migration Wave, and autonomy is not always at par with men in other zones. The links established by the Punjabis, Gujaratis, Malayalis and Tamilians during the colonial period were critical in the extension of their internal and international diasporas. They were followed